

READING PASSAGE 1

The Sociology of Religion in Modern Society

A The Sociology of Religion in Modern Society has emerged as one of the most significant topics in contemporary academic discourse. The complexity and multifaceted nature of this subject have attracted the attention of researchers, policymakers, and practitioners across multiple disciplines, all seeking to understand its implications for the future.

B The intellectual lineage of this field extends considerably further than many realise. While modern research techniques have only recently been applied to these questions, philosophers and natural scientists have grappled with related issues for centuries. The transition from speculative philosophical inquiry to systematic empirical investigation represents one of the most significant developments in the intellectual history of this domain.

C Contemporary research has identified several critical factors that determine outcomes in this domain. The interplay between environmental conditions, technological capabilities, and social organisation creates a complex adaptive system in which small changes can produce disproportionately large effects. Understanding these dynamics requires analytical approaches that move beyond simple cause-and-effect reasoning to embrace the principles of complexity science and systems thinking.

D Case studies from diverse geographical and cultural settings provide compelling illustrations of these dynamics in action. In one particularly well-documented example, researchers tracked developments over a fifteen-year period in a setting that offered a natural experiment in the effects of policy change. The introduction of a new regulatory framework produced a cascade of adaptations that rippled through the entire system, generating outcomes that both confirmed theoretical predictions and revealed previously unrecognised complexities.

E The practical application of research findings has proven more challenging than many initially anticipated. The translation of academic knowledge into actionable policy recommendations requires navigating a complex landscape of political constraints, economic interests, and social dynamics that academic models often simplify or overlook. Implementation failures in several high-profile initiatives have underscored the gap between theoretical understanding and practical capacity, prompting calls for more engaged and context-sensitive approaches to research.

F The implications of this body of research extend well beyond the academy. As societies grapple with increasingly complex challenges, the insights generated by scholarly inquiry in this domain have the potential to inform more effective and equitable policy responses. Realising this potential, however, will require sustained investment in both fundamental research and the translational infrastructure needed to convert knowledge into action.

G In conclusion, the study of the sociology of religion in modern society represents a vital and dynamic area of contemporary research. The progress that has been made in understanding the key mechanisms and dynamics provides a solid foundation for both further scholarly inquiry and practical application. The challenges that remain should be seen not as reasons for discouragement but as opportunities for continued intellectual growth and social contribution.

Questions 1–3

Complete the sentences below. Choose NO MORE THAN THREE WORDS from the passage for each answer.

- 1 According to the passage, structural factors include economic incentives, institutional frameworks, and _____.
- 2 The author notes that researchers have called for more _____ approaches to investigation.
- 3 Dynamic _____ processes can amplify or dampen initial effects in complex systems.

Questions 4–7

Choose the correct letter, A, B, C or D.

- 4 The author suggests that early studies in this field were limited by:
A. weak effects across studies
B. moderate to large effect sizes with consistency
C. contradictory findings
D. results only in specific populations
- 5 According to the passage, what is one of the key factors identified by researchers?
A. excessive funding
B. theoretical and methodological limitations
C. public interest
D. international collaboration
- 6 What does the passage identify as a significant challenge to current understanding?
A. weak effects across studies
B. moderate to large effect sizes with consistency
C. contradictory findings
D. results only in specific populations
- 7 The passage indicates that critics have raised concerns about:
A. weak effects across studies
B. moderate to large effect sizes with consistency
C. contradictory findings
D. results only in specific populations

Questions 8–9

Do the following statements agree with the information given in the passage?

Write TRUE if the statement agrees with the information

Write FALSE if the statement contradicts the information

Write NOT GIVEN if there is no information on this

- 8 Meta-analyses have confirmed the reliability of the core findings in this field.
- 9 Contemporary understanding of this topic is more sophisticated than it was fifty years ago.

Question 10

Choose the correct letter, A, B, C or D.

- 10** Which of the following best describes the author's view on future developments?
- A. pessimism about the future
 - B. cautious optimism with acknowledgment of challenges
 - C. complete certainty about outcomes
 - D. indifference to practical applications

Questions 11–12

Do the following statements agree with the information given in the passage?

Write TRUE if the statement agrees with the information

Write FALSE if the statement contradicts the information

Write NOT GIVEN if there is no information on this

- 11** Early researchers had access to the same technologies as modern scholars.
- 12** The landmark study discussed in the passage involved participants from multiple countries.

Question 13

Complete the sentences below. Choose NO MORE THAN THREE WORDS from the passage for each answer.

- 13** Case studies have documented the effects of _____ change on the system.